Genesis 2-4

Eden & Cain Stories

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- The following study will recognize that these chapters are stories and therefore consider them from a ***literary perspective***
  - What is its structure?
  - How are the stories set up?
  - Who are the main characters?
  - What are the issues?
  - How are they developed?
  - What is the overall message?
  - How does it fit into its larger context?

Structure

- Indicators of section ***beginning*** in Gen 2:4
  - Declaration in 2:1-3 that creation is complete
  - Introduction with a *toledot* ("*this is what came out of*")
  - Change in narrative style from a formal, poetic, seven-day structure, to a story-type presentation
  - Change in the name used for God *(Elohim to Yahweh Elohim)*
  - Change in perspective from outside the earth looking in, to a specific locality on earth
  - Introduction of humans as active participants

Structure

- Indicators of section ***ending*** at end of Genesis 4
  - Occurrence of another *toledot* in 5:1
  - Change in form from a story-type presentation to a genealogy

Structure

- Major Episode Break at End of Chapter 3
  - Eden narrative starts with a lack of man to till the earth and ends with man tilling the earth
  - With the story of Cain . . .
    - there is a change in location from Eden to the land outside Eden
    - there is the introduction of new characters
    - the story centers around a new character

Structure

- The Eden narrative and story of Cain are actually ***two parts*** of ***one larger whole***
  - The story of Cain is introduced via the characters of the Eden narrative
  - The story of Cain ends with the characters of the Eden narrative
  - There are numerous parallels between the stories

Structure

- Eden Narrative and Cain Story Parallels
  - Principal characters are introduced in terms of their functions.
  - Each episode presents two characters given life, and in harmony with one another.
  - Each episode includes a word of warning prior to their respective sins.
  - The characters are confronted by God who exposes their sin by posing leading questions.
  - God pronounces sentence.
  - The characters are driven from their original context.
  - The characters experience a degree of separation from God.
  - The characters move “eastward.”

Structure

- The implications of structure of a story and its sequel:
  - ***the second serves as a development of the first***.
  - the ***principles introduced*** in the Eden narrative should be understood as ***further developed*** in the story of Cain.

The Knowledge of Good and Evil

What is it?

Usual Approaches

- Two Categories
  - Theological

    These approaches tend to consider the matter from outside the text
  - Exegetical

    These approaches consider the matter from the context of the Eden narrative

Usual Approaches

- Theological
  - Knowledge of sin
  - Knowledge of death
  - Loss of innocence
  - Wisdom
- Exegetical
  - Sexual knowledge
  - Divine knowledge

Our Methodology

- Terminological *(meaning and usage of terms)*
- Exegetical *(based on context)*
- Literary *(considering narrative flow and emphases)*
- Validation
  - Begin with a study of terminology
  - Verify with a literary study

Terminology

- The Hebrew words for “good” and “evil”
  - “Good” *(tov)*
    - refers to welfare in general,
    - that which is ***beneficial***.
    - “Good” is an accurate English translation
  - “evil” *(rah)*
    - Refers to that which is ***detrimental***,
    - Can be used of moral evil as well as unfortunate events.
    - An English equivalent would be “bad.”

Terminology

The **Expression** "Good and Bad"

- "Good and bad" does not necessarily mean "good" in addition to "bad'
- Generally used in a context which involves a clear ***differentiation*** between good and bad (e.g., Genesis 1)
- Generally involves an emphasis on ***discernment*** between the two
- Generally involves an emphasis on ***maintaining the distinction*** between the two

Terminology

Knowing "good and bad"

- occurs eight times in the Bible
  - Four occurrences ***in*** the Eden narrative
  - Four occurrences ***outside*** the Eden narrative

Terminology

Knowing "good and bad"

- Occurrences outside the Eden narrative
  - Isa 7:15-16 (the promised child)
    - The issue is not good and bad, *per se*, but rather the ability to choose appropriately between the two, associated with maturity.
  - 2 Sam 19:36 (Barzillai)
    - Again, the issue is not good and bad, *per se*, but the ability to distinguish between the two
  - Deut 1:39
    - A lack of knowledge of good and bad is associated with the vulnerability and dependency of children.

Terminology

Knowing "good and bad"

- All occurrences outside the Eden narrative use "knowing good and bad" in a context associated with maturity, and specifically, ***dependence*** or ***independence***.
- Extrabiblical usage of the expression is similar:

And this is the rule for all the armies of the congregation, for all native Israelites. From his youth they shall educate him . . . during ten years he will be counted amongst the boys. At the age of twenty years he will transfer to those enrolled to enter the lot amongst his family and join the holy community. He shall not approach a woman to know her through carnal intercourse until he is fully twenty years old, when he knows good and bad.

Rule of the Congregation (1QSa 1.16-11)

Terminology

Knowing "good and bad"

In both biblical and extrabiblical usages, the expression refers to the matter of ***maturity*** . . .

and particularly the issue of . . .

dependence versus independence.

Therefore, the expression refers to ***independence in assessing what is beneficial and detrimental.***

Literary Issues

- From a literary perspective, a satisfactory solution must adequately address the following:
  - God's statement, "Man has become like one of us, to know good and bad."
  - The narrator's use of, and the characters' reactions to, the matter of nakedness.

Literary Issues

"Like one of us"

- The serpent said, "You will be as God/gods, knowers of good and bad." (Gen 3:5)
- God said, "They have become like one of us, to know good and bad." (Gen 3:22)
- ***How does knowing good and bad make them like God/gods?***

Literary Issues

"Like one of us"

- The relationship between the serpent's "You will be as God/gods" and God's "they have become like one of us" implies that "knowing good and bad" is the same thing in both cases.
- But, **who are** those that already know good and bad.

Literary Issues

"Like one of us"

- Who knows good and bad?
  - God?
  - The gods?
  - Angels?
- A clue to the referent is found in the usage of God's name

Literary Issues

"Like one of us"

- God's name in the Eden Narrative
  - Throughout the Eden story, the ***narrator*** always refers to God as "Yahweh Elohim."
  - The only times he is not referred to in this manner is by ***the characters*** themselves, in the conversation between the serpent and the woman.

Literary Issues

"Like one of us"

- Conversation between the serpent and the woman
  - Usage #1: "Did Elohim say . . ."
    - This refers to a previous conversation in the narrative and one in which the narrator attributes the saying to "Yahweh Elohim."
    - Therefore, the referent in the mind of the serpent is clearly God.
  - Usage #2:
    - The woman refers to the same conversation, referring to God as Elohim, as did the serpent.

Literary Issues

"Like one of us"

- Conversation between the serpent and the woman
  - Usage #3: "God knows . . ."
    - Based on usage 1 & 2, the serpent is clearly referring to God
  - Usage #4: "you will be as Gods/gods")

    In the ***one*** conversation in which Elohim is used,

    in a story in which God is always referred to as Yahweh Elohim,

    in which three usages of Elohim clearly refer to God,

    the fourth must certainly be understood in the same manner.

Literary Issues

"Like one of us"

- If it refers to God, then "knowing good and bad" is best understood as an attribute of God rather than angelic beings or the heavenly council (i.e., "gods").
- This view meshes with God being portrayed in chapter 1 as the one with ultimate, independent discernment, the nuance indicated by the foregoing terminological study.

Literary Issues

- If "knowing good and bad" is something initially attributed only to God but then acquired by humanity, then it must be understood in a way which makes sense in both cases.
- Options:
  - Awareness of morality in contrast to innocence
  - Independence in discernment

Literary Issues

Awareness of Morality?

- Makes sense in reference to both God and humanity, but . . .
  conflicts with the foregoing terminological study . . .
  and conflicts with scholarly consensus that “good” and “bad” refer to that which is beneficial and detrimental.

Literary Issues

Independence in Discernment

- Makes sense applied to God
  - ***Theologically***, God is uniquely capable of independently ascertaining what is beneficial and detrimental
  - ***Contextually***, God is portrayed in Genesis 1 as the one who sovereignly and independently discerns
    - God creates, separates, and names
    - God determines that seeds and animals reproduce "after their kind" maintaining their creative distinction
    - God determines what is good and not good

Literary Issues

Independence in Discernment

- Makes sense applied to humanity
  - The concept is understandable theologically
  - Corresponds to contextual themes and emphases
    - The characterization of trees as pleasant to the sight and good for food (2:9) is apparently from a human perspective
    - Naming of animals requires discernment
    - The man's reaction to the creation of the woman demonstrates discernment

Literary Issues

Independence in Discernment

- Since the narrative portrays the man as exercising discernment in a number of ways, what changes when he acquires the knowledge of good and bad?

Independence

Literary Issues

Independence in discernment

- God initiated discernment
  - Benefit of trees
  - Naming animals
  - Suitability of the woman

BUT, eating from the tree was direct disobedience and therefore ***independence!***

Again, the knowledge of good and bad refers to ***independence*** in assessing what is beneficial and detrimental.

Literary Issues

Presentation of Nakedness

- The problem: Is nakedness good or bad?
  - If bad, why were the man and woman created naked?
  - If bad, why was their lack of shame portrayed positively?
  - If good, why did disobedience result in shame?
- The meaning of "the knowledge of good and bad" must adequately address these questions since acquiring it is the basis for their changed attitude toward nakedness.

Literary Issues

Presentation of Nakedness

- Unity in plurality of humanity
  - Emphasis in Day 6 *(image of God)*
  - Emphasis in Eden narrative *("bone of my bone . . .")*
  - Nakedness is the final narrative statement emphasizing this unity.
- So, what's the problem with nakedness after the fall?

Literary Issues

Presentation of Nakedness

- The problem is ***shame*** rather than nakedness itself
  - Biblical Connotation:

    Nakedness is being laid bare before the world, made open and vulnerable (Gen 42:9, 12; Isa 20; Ezek 16:22, 39; 23:22-35; Hos 2)
  - Contextually . . .
    - nakedness cannot be simply physical since the man hid from the Lord because he was naked,
    - ***even though he had already covered himself with leaves!***

The issue is his self-awareness!

Literary Issues

Presentation of Nakedness

- Shame as the issue
  - meshes with the knowledge of good and bad as independence in discernment.
  - Lack of shame in nakedness portrays lack of awareness of self as a separate entity, i.e., unity in plurality
  - Acquisition of independence in discernment makes one self-aware, resulting in shame in nakedness

The Knowledge of Good & Bad

Conclusion

- The knowledge of good and bad refers to ***independence in discerning what is beneficial and detrimental***
  - Coincides with the terminological study
  - Coincides with the literary presentation of the narrative
  - Coincides with the portrayal of nakedness
  - Reinforces the narrative focus on unity in plurality